JD DRAMA PUBLISHING

My Life in Babysitters

By D'Arcy Robb

Author's note: DAVID should be played by the same actor throughout. The roles of MOM, GRETA, ELENA and DARSIE/JESSICA may be performed by one actor (possibly with onstage changes of hat/wig/glasses etc. to quickly differentiate each character) or by multiple actors. This also could be performed as humorous interpretation with one actor portraying all the roles.
DAVID alternates between addressing the audience and speaking directly to the other characters. For the entire section between DAVID and MOM, both characters are addressing the audience, with the sole exception of MOM's first line.

DAVID: Until I was nine, my mom was just a mom. She prepared balanced snacks, wiped noses and pretended she really liked the scribbly artwork all over our refrigerator. But then one day the game changed.
MOM: (*to DAVID*) Things are going to change, sweetie.
DAVID: Turns out once upon a time, my mom had a whole other life beyond our kitchen. She had a thing called a PhD. And now that I was past a "critical developmental stage" it was time to start PhD-ing again.
MOM: Holding office hours will allow both David and me space to develop our independent identities.
DAVID: Did I mention her PhD is in psychology?
MOM: And spending time with another caregiver will give David the chance to absorb different life skills that he might not get from me.
DAVID: Anyway. For mom to go back and psychogize, we needed something we'd never had before. We needed a babysitter.

Most families in search of a babysitter look within about a five mile range. But thanks to an outfit called Nannies International, my family went for the 5,000 mile range.
GRETA: Your son is very small. Is he runt or you just don't feed him?
DAVID: That was how we got Greta.
GRETA: In my family we keel the runts! Ha-ha-ha.
DAVID: Now I know what you're thinking. Bratty American kid. Making fun of Greta because she doesn't talk like him.
GRETA: I don't believe in ice cubes. They are very bad for you.
DAVID: Nah. I made fun of her because Greta was just weird. She also had big plans -- for the underdeveloped field of children's extreme strength training.
GRETA: I have a present for you, Little David.
DAVID: Cool! Thanks. (*pause*) It's….a bag of rocks.
GRETA: Now you carry it across the yard ten times.
DAVID: I'm not sure why, but I went along with it. Mom would have said I was "conducting a real-life experiment in alternative lifestyles". But it was so freaky, I just wanted to see what she'd do next.
GRETA: Squeeze, squeeze those bananas out of their shells! You must develop strong finger muscles.
DAVID: Things went on like that for a couple months. When we were at the pool, she'd say stuff like --
GRETA: You are fastest fishyshark in the world, David! Mermaids cannot escape you!
DAVID: That was pretty cool. It gave me a reason to chase stupid girls. But everything came to a head with Greta when word got out that a bear was loose in our neighborhood.
GRETA: Bear is a powerful animal, David. But you are more powerful. You will catch this bear and skin him for slippers.
DAVID: Um, okay. (*Mimes chasing and skinning a bear and putting on a slipper*)
GRETA: But where is the bear?
DAVID: Oh. (*Fishes under his seat, pulls out a teddy bear*) Here he is!
GRETA: You think this is a joke? Go get real bear!
DAVID: Real bear?
GRETA: Real bear!

DAVID: Um….Greta, I don't know how to do that. And I think it's against the law.
GRETA: You Americans and your law. Fine. I will catch real bear.
DAVID: I think we should wait till mom gets home!
(to audience) But Greta wouldn't wait. And a few hours later….
GRETA: (*out of breath*) I have you now, demon beast! See, David. I catch bear.
DAVID: Greta?
GRETA: Yes?
DAVID: You're bleeding.
GRETA: Yes.
DAVID: *(to audience)* It wasn't a bear after all, just a really big, scared Newfoundland dog. The dog was okay, and Greta got a few stitches and scars out of it. But mom wasn't too happy that Greta left me alone at home to go bear hunting. Not too long after that, mom found my bag of rocks and Greta's time at our house came to an end.
And we started looking for babysitter number two.
ELENA: Primarily I'm a stage actress, but I would consider film.
DAVID: Elena is who we found.
ELENA: Just like Kate Hepburn.
DAVID: Elena was dedicated to her "craft". Even though most of her roles were things like "Dog Walker" and Girl #2", she put acting ahead of everything. Including her job. Which in this case, happened to be me.
(to ELENA) Um, Elena?
ELENA: (*reading from script*)….Why, Uncle Allen! You don't say!
DAVID: Elena?
ELENA: Why, Uncle Allen. You DON'T say….
(*to David*) What?
DAVID: I'm kind of hungry.
ELENA: (*pause, still absorbed in script*) Okay.
DAVID: Isn't it time to make dinner?
ELENA: Art doesn't work around your schedule, David. Time is relative.
DAVID: Can I have some food anyway?
ELENA: Go ahead.

DAVID: But I don't know how to use the stove by myself.
ELENA: Push some buttons. You'll figure it out.
(*back to script*) Surely, Uncle! I'd love to!
DAVID: *(to audience)* I became more interesting to Elena once she began to see me as a captive audience-slash-line feeder.
(to ELENA) Hey Elena, why are you digging up the garden?
ELENA: I need to understand my character's potato farm childhood.
DAVID: Oh.
ELENA: Do you know how to read?
DAVID: I'm in fourth grade.
ELENA: So that's a yes? (*hands him script*) Read River Moon's lines.
DAVID: (*flat voice*) Rose. You are as beautiful as a rose bush.
ELENA: No, no, no. You've got to FEEL the lines. INHABIT the character.
DAVID: ROSE! You are as BEAUTIFUL as a BUSH!
ELENA: David, I can't respond to you as Rose until you speak to me as River Moon.
DAVID: But I don't know anything about River Moon.
ELENA: River Moon is a simplistic but deeply troubled young man whose love for Rose is matched only by his commitment to soybean farming.
DAVID: Oh.
(*in his normal voice*) Rose, you are as beautiful as a rose bush.
ELENA: (*to DAVID*) Yes!!
(in character as Rose) River Moon, how the fields are sparkling tonight!
DAVID: *(to audience)* Elena's biggest roles were in plays written by her friends. That one was called "Beautiful Farm Child". She was always really excited when she landed a new part.
ELENA: David! Today we need to undertake an actor's treasure hunt!
DAVID: Okay! (*to audience*) This was the most interest Elena had ever had in me.
ELENA: Do you have any rope?
DAVID: I think mom has some in the garage. (*mimes handing rope to her*) Here it is.
ELENA: Good. What about pliers, matches and carving knives?

DAVID: Toolshed, pantry and kitchen. Want me to get them?
ELENA: *(begins wrapping rope around DAVID)* No. Hold still.
DAVID: Elena, why are you tying me up?
ELENA: Because you are going to help me become Mary Josephine Baker.
DAVID: Who's Mary Josephine Baker?
ELENA: Mary Josephine Baker is a misunderstood serial killer from the 1960's. She tied up her victims and befriended them before torturing and killing them.
DAVID: MOM!!!
(to audience) Obviously my mom wasn't around, but I screamed loud enough that the neighbors heard me. They "recommended" to mom that Elena not watch me anymore. So we moved on to babysitter #3.
JESSICA: Your name is David?? I used to go out with a guy named David!
DAVID: Mom thought it might be good to go with someone more -- social.
JESSICA: I also went out with another guy named Dave.
DAVID: Jessica was social all right – if by "social" you mean date-crazed and somewhat manic.
JESSICA: Oh my Gucci and holy Prada! It's a sign. You're going to date someone with my name. Do you think you know her?
DAVID: Know who?
JESSICA: The Jessica you're going to go out with! Do you know her already?
DAVID: You're the only person named Jessica that I know, Jessica.
JESSICA: Oh, David. It's cute that you're flirting with me, but really kind of inappropriate.
DAVID: I wasn't trying to --
JESSICA: *(cutting him off)* It's okay, I get it all the time.
DAVID: Perhaps unsurprisingly, Jessica had never babysat before.
JESSICA: I've just always been so busy with my social life! I could be doing way more fun things right now, but I have to prioritize. I need money for this killer prom gown.
DAVID: *(to audience)* I didn't really care, as long as she wasn't going to tie me up with the sash.
JESSICA: I bet you're one of the smart kids, aren't you?

DAVID: I don't know. I guess.
JESSICA: It's okay. Nobody's perfect. When you get to be my age, you'll be one of those guys who's kind of cute but doesn't talk to anyone outside, like, calculus class.
DAVID: That would be okay if everyone I wanted to talk to was in calculus class.
JESSICA: It's sad that you already feel that way! You might never date someone pretty.
DAVID: I'm nine. I don't want to date anyone.
JESSICA: But someday you will want to date someone! And wouldn't you rather date someone, well, who looks like me?
DAVID: *(to audience)* I had no idea what the right answer to that was.
JESSICA: I know! We'll practice!
DAVID: We'll practice what?
JESSICA: How you talk to pretty girls.
DAVID: No! Uh, no, that's okay Jessica. I think I'll go play Dungeons and Dragons.
JESSICA: Dating is way more important than Draggers and Daggers, David. You be you, and I'll be the girl.
DAVID: But….fine. Okay. *(long silence. DAVID mimes leafing through a magazine, flipping TV channels, etc.)*
JESSICA: What are you doing?
DAVID: Being me. I don't have anything to say.
JESSICA: You've got to say something.
DAVID: *(long pause, flat voice)* Hi.
JESSICA: Hi!
DAVID: How are you today?
JESSICA: No, that's kind of boring.
DAVID: Nice weather, isn't it?
JESSICA: Ugh. Boring.
DAVID: Want to play Dungeons and Dragons?
JESSICA: Oh, my Gucci.
DAVID: That's not boring to me!
JESSICA: You know what? I'm trying to help you and you don't appreciate it. You're just like my math tutor.
DAVID: Your math tutor?
JESSICA: You smarty-smarts think you're smart at everything. I'm trying to show you how to have a life but you're all like too

good for it already. You are so on your way to being one of those cute nerdy jerks who's totally clueless about romance.
DAVID: Actually, I do know something about romance. *(clears throat, gets into character as an awkward, slow-talking River Moon. Addresses JESSICA)* You are as beautiful as a rose bush. *(pause)* The fields sparkle tonight, my love, but never shall they sparkle as brilliantly as you. My rosy rosy love! Your skin is as firm as a ripe tomato. Your eyes glow like lightning bugs and your smell is sweeter than fresh dirt.
Pause. JESSICA stares at DAVID, horrified.
JESSICA: You -- are -- way more messed up than I thought. It's bad enough to be a repressed nerd. It is totally sick be in love with your babysitter, especially one with a steady boyfriend!
DAVID: I didn't mean it like that. It's just - that's what I know about romance.
JESSICA: Just because I'm beautiful and older than you, you do not have the right to make me feel uncomfortable!
DAVID: You're the one who wanted me to practice talking to girls!
JESSICA: Sure, take my kindness and turn it against me. You are one weird little kid! This is not worth the price of a beaded prom gown. And your mom – needs to take you to Scouts or something. You obviously need to go outside more often. *(JESSICA exits)*
DAVID addresses the audience.
DAVID: My babysitter years are behind me now. But Mom was right. I did learn important life skills from my sitters that I never would have gotten from her.
I can carry a bag of rocks for miles. I don't even feel it when they jab me in the butt.
I never give anyone a rope without first clarifying what they intend to use it for.
And when girls start talking about dating and romance – if I need to end the conversation, I say, "Your eyes remind me of lightning bugs. And you smell – just like fresh dirt."

Curtain.

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"D'Arcy Robb is the author of several short scripts available from J.D. Drama. She is a former journalist who finds writing inspiration in her experiences as a youth sports coach, babysitter and camp counselor. D'Arcy and her husband Todd share their home with three resident cats and a changing roster of foster animals. She is currently at work on her first one-act play."

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